Monday, November 2, 2026
All Souls' Day

St. Odilo of Cluny

Abbot of Cluny · Feast, January 19



St. Odilo, Founder of the Commemoration of the Faithful Departed, unknown French painter, 17th century[1]

1. Unknown French painter, *St. Odilo, Abbot, First Founder of the Commemoration of the Faithful Departed*, oil on canvas, 200 × 111 cm, 17th century (formerly Auktionshaus Aldag).

Today the Church prays for all the faithful departed. St. Odilo, abbot of Cluny, is the man who established this day: he set November 2 apart in Cluny and its monasteries, and the practice soon spread to the whole Church.[2]

✠ The Essentials

- **Origin:** Auvergne, in central France, from a noble family.[3] Butler names the family as the lords of Mercœur, "one of the most illustrious of Auvergne."[4]
- **Born:** c. 962[5]
- **Died:** January 1, 1049, at the priory of Souvigny, while visiting his monasteries. After five years of painful illness he "died of the cholic," aged eighty-seven, after fifty-six years as abbot.[6] The Catholic Encyclopedia gives the date as December 31, 1048.[7] He was buried at Souvigny and soon venerated as a saint.[8]
- **Feast:** formerly January 2 at Cluny, now January 19.[9]
- **Canonized:** St. Peter Damian began the process of his canonization in 1063.[10] In 1793 revolutionaries burned his relics.[11]

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2. Klemens Löffler, "St. Odilo," in *The Catholic Encyclopedia*, vol. 11 (New York: Robert Appleton Company, 1911).
3. Ibid.
4. Alban Butler, *The Lives of the Fathers, Martyrs, and Other Principal Saints*, vol. 1, January 1, "St. Odilo, or Olon, Sixth Abbot of Cluni."
5. Löffler, "St. Odilo."
6. Butler, *Lives*, January 1.
7. Löffler, "St. Odilo."
8. Ibid.
9. Ibid.
10. Ibid.
11. Ibid.

✠ His Life in Brief

Odilo entered Cluny in 991. Before his year of probation ended he was made coadjutor to Abbot Mayeul, and he became abbot shortly before Mayeul's death in 994.[12] Under him the number of Cluniac monasteries grew from thirty-seven to sixty-five.[13] He placed reformed houses permanently under Cluny, giving the Church its first religious order in the full sense.[14]

- Fulbert of Chartres called him the "Archangel of the Monks."[15]
- Two popes offered him the archbishopric of Lyons, and he declined.[16]
- In the famine of 1006 he melted down sacred vessels to feed the poor.[17] In the famines of 1028–33 his charity saved thousands from death.[18]
- He worked for the Peace of God (the Truce of God), which limited private warfare.[19]
- His surviving writings include a life of the Empress St. Adelaide, sermons, hymns and prayers.[20]

12. Ibid.
13. Ibid.
14. John Coulson, ed., *The Saints: A Concise Biographical Dictionary* (New York: Hawthorn Books, 1960), s.v. "Odilo, St."
15. Löffler, "St. Odilo."
16. Ibid.
17. Butler, *Lives*, January 1.
18. Löffler, "St. Odilo."
19. Ibid.
20. Ibid.

✠ Famous Excerpt: from Butler's *Lives of the Saints*

> *"It was usual with him to say, that of two extremes, he chose rather to offend by tenderness, than a too rigid severity."*[21]

> *"St. Odilo being moved by several visions, instituted the annual commemoration of all the faithful departed, to be observed by the members of his community with alms, prayers, and sacrifices, for the relief of the suffering souls in purgatory; and this charitable devotion he often much recommended."*[22]

✠ 1. Catechesis

Lesson: Purgatory and prayer for the dead. Odilo's three works for the dead, "alms, prayers, and sacrifices," match what the Church still teaches.

- Those who "die in God's grace and friendship, but still imperfectly purified" are assured of salvation but undergo purification after death (CCC 1030).[23]
- The Church calls this final purification of the elect Purgatory, and it is "entirely different from the punishment of the damned" (CCC 1031).[24]
- The Church offers the Eucharistic sacrifice for the dead and "also commends almsgiving, indulgences, and works of penance undertaken on behalf of the dead" (CCC 1032).[25]

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21. Butler, *Lives*, January 1.
22. Ibid.
23. *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, 2nd ed. (Vatican City: Libreria Editrice Vaticana, 1997), no. 1030.
24. *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, 2nd ed. (Vatican City: Libreria Editrice Vaticana, 1997), no. 1031.
25. *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, 2nd ed. (Vatican City: Libreria Editrice Vaticana, 1997), no. 1032.

Ask students to name one of the three works they can do for someone who has died this week.

✠ 2. Apologetics

Objection: "Purgatory isn't in the Bible, and prayer for the dead is a medieval invention." Odilo did not invent prayer for the dead; he gave it a fixed day. The practice is in Scripture: Judas Maccabeus "made atonement for the dead, that they might be delivered from their sin" (2 Macc 12:46, cited in CCC 1032).[26] Christ speaks of sins that will not be forgiven "in this age or in the age to come" (Mt 12:32). St. Gregory the Great concluded from this that "certain offenses can be forgiven in this age, but certain others in the age to come" (CCC 1031).[27] St. Paul describes one who "will be saved, but only as through fire" (1 Cor 3:15). And the Church has honored the memory of the dead "from the very earliest days of the Christian religion" (CCC 958).[28]

Note for discussion: 2 Maccabees is in the Catholic and Orthodox canon but not in most Protestant Bibles. Even read as history alone, it shows Jews praying for the dead before Christ.

✠ 3. Theology

- **The communion of saints includes the dead:** "Our prayer for them is capable not only of helping them, but also of making their intercession for us effective" (CCC 958).[29] All Saints and All

26. Ibid.
27. *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, no. 1031.
28. *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, 2nd ed. (Vatican City: Libreria Editrice Vaticana, 1997), no. 958.
29. Ibid.

Souls belong together: Odilo placed the commemoration of the dead on the day after All Saints.[30]

- **Charity and the social order:** His feeding of the poor in famine and his work for the Peace of God show monastic prayer turning into public charity and peace.[31][32]
- **The Incarnation:** Butler records that when the monks sang the verse of the Te Deum, "thou being to take upon thee to deliver man, didst not abhor the womb of a virgin," Odilo fell to the ground overcome with love.[33]

✠ 4. Devotional Prayer

Collect for the Commemoration of All the Faithful Departed (Roman Missal, November 2):[34]

Listen kindly to our prayer, O Lord, and as our faith in your Son, raised from the dead, is deepened, so may our hope of resurrection for your departed servants also find new strength. Through our Lord Jesus Christ, your Son, who lives and reigns with you in the unity of the Holy Spirit, God, for ever and ever. Amen.

Prayer after death (*Order of Christian Funerals*):[35]

V. Eternal rest grant unto him/her, O Lord.
R. And let perpetual light shine upon him/her.
V. May he/she rest in peace.
R. Amen.
V. May his/her soul and the souls of all the faithful departed, through the

30. Coulson, *The Saints*, s.v. "Odilo."
31. Löffler, "St. Odilo."
32. Ibid.
33. Butler, *Lives*, January 1.
34. *The Roman Missal*, 3rd typical ed., English trans. (ICEL, 2011), November 2, Commemoration of All the Faithful Departed, Collect.
35. *Order of Christian Funerals*, English trans. (ICEL, 1985, 1989), Prayers after Death.

mercy of God, rest in peace.
R. Amen.

Practice: Do what Odilo asked of his monks today: give alms, pray, and offer the Mass for someone who has died.[36]

✠ Today's Takeaway

Our love for the dead does not end at the grave. Odilo "chose rather to offend by tenderness, than a too rigid severity," and he extended that tenderness to the souls in purgatory.[37]

St. Odilo, pray for us. Eternal rest grant unto them, O Lord.

36. Butler, *Lives*, January 1.
37. Ibid.